

ARAIYA FUNK
PRICE:
Rs 1,500 onwards
NUMBER OF STORES:
Five Shoppers'
Stop outlets

Arshiya Fakhri's cost-effective brand boasts of chiffon dresses and tops.

prêt collection at the Delhi Fashion Week, Tahiliani sent out an entire range of denim shorts, skirts and jeans which will soon be available at select Levi's stores for Rs 7,000 and above.

Though the country has been bombarded with too many ramp shows in the last month, the actual orders being placed still remain a grey area, making it increasingly clear that the aspiring domestic buyer can't be overlooked. But if there is a demand and there are an equal number of designers out there—for the record, 75 showed at Lakme Fashion Week alone—why is it that we are aware of only a handful? "Designers can't reach out because in India they still don't have that kind of infrastructure required to produce in bulk," says Gaurav Mahajan, head of

buying, Westside. This problem is solved by a big retail unit that takes care of the production and leaves the creative process to the designers.

Surprisingly, apparel isn't the only medium through which designers are making their presence felt today. While Ritu Kumar and Rocky S have launched fragrances, others like Dayal have signed up with Portico to create an exclusive line of furnishings. This means bringing home a set of designer duvet, bed sheet and pillow cover for just Rs 5,500 even when a regular joe tunic by the same designer could cost anything above Rs 6,000. "Tie-ups give both parties a new customer base. We get people who are looking for something expensive while designers get customers who want to break out of their niche clientele," says Portico CEO Rajeev Merchant.

There is more style candy in the store for the average consumer. Designer duo Shane and Falguni Peacock decided to shake things up this season by starting a new affordable label, Spendthrift. "We have always done couture that starts at Rs 7,000 but today if you have to be available to the masses you have to be price sensitive," says Peacock. "As international buyers shrink we will have to target the domestic market," says designer Abdul Halder, who has still not veered towards prêt but is now considering it.

Arshiya Fakhri executed similar thoughts some time ago. She recently showcased her collection Araiya Funk aimed at the 20-something audience, consisting of knee-length and long dresses and some tops. "This is what I call watered-down designer wear," she says. Fakhri's line will soon be available at select Shoppers' Stop outlets for Rs 1,500 and above. Ahmed is operating in the same price range too, by launching his new label Nari Nari after a decade on the runway. "The problem is that most designers either can't or don't want to get down to that level. They think it might tarnish their reputation," says Ahmed, explaining why we haven't witnessed accessible fashion already. But with an international slowdown upon us and with designers wooing the local market, that inaccessible shift dress that you have been eyeing might soon find its way into your wardrobe. ■

TARUN TAHILIANI FOR LEVI'S ▼

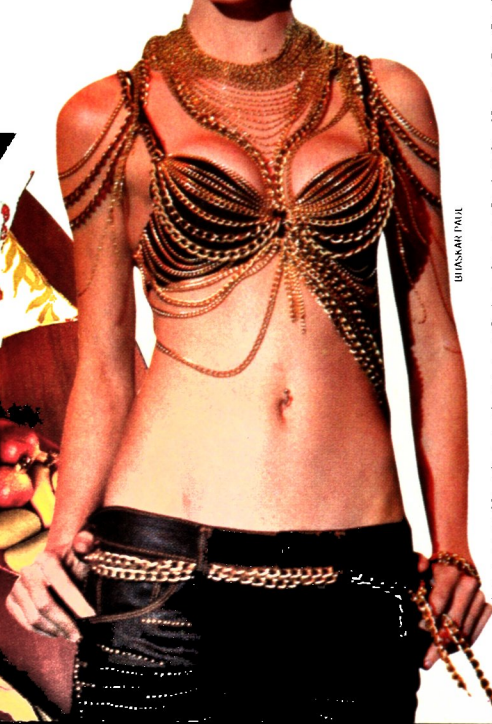
PRICE: Rs 7,000 onwards

NUMBER OF STORES: Few Levi's outlets

Crystals, embellishments, silver chains and a whole lot of bling on denim.

ANUPAMA DAYAL
FOR PORTICO
PRICE: Rs 5,500 for set
NUMBER OF STORES: 160
shop-in-shop counters

Four designers have collaborated with the company to give the furnishings market something more.



SHANE AND FALGUN PEACOCK

